Running Claude Code for Free Locally on Your Laptop: A Step-by-Step Guide

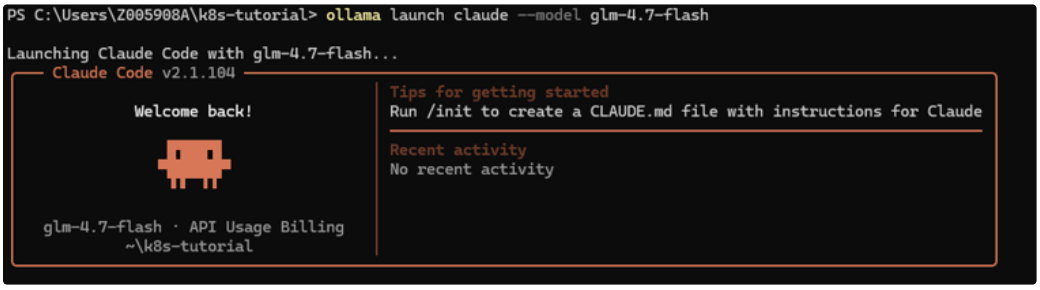
I ran Claude Code for free on my laptop. Here's how.

Claude Code is incredible. It reads your files, writes code, runs commands. All from your terminal.

The problem? It's expensive. $100/month minimum if you use it daily.

So I found a way to run it for free. Locally. On my Windows laptop.

Here's the exact setup I used.



Claude Code, running on a local model. Zero API costs.

What you need

- A laptop with at least 8 GB RAM (16 GB+ is better)
- Windows, macOS, or Linux
- 20 minutes

That's it.

Step 1 Install Ollama

Ollama lets you run AI models locally. Think of it as the engine.

Go to Ollama , download the installer for your OS, run it.

Verify it works:

```
ollama --version
```

Step 2 Pull a model

This downloads the actual AI brain to your machine. You can check the list of the models here.

To check which models you can run on your machine, try this website that gives you information about various models and their machine requirements CanIRun.ai — Can your machine run AI models?

```
ollama pull glm-4.7-flash
```

For better results (needs 16 GB RAM):

```
ollama pull qwen2.5-coder:14b
```

Step 3 Install Claude Code

Windows CMD:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.cmd -o install.cmd && install.cmd
&& del install.cmd
```

Mac/Linux:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

Then add it to your PATH so your terminal can find it. On Windows, run this in PowerShell:

```
[Environment]::SetEnvironmentVariable("PATH", $env:PATH +
";C:\Users\YOURUSERNAME\.local\bin", "User")
```

Restart your terminal. Then verify:

```
claude --version
```

Step 4 Launch it

```
ollama launch claude --model glm-4.7-flash
```

You're in. Ask it anything about your codebase.

Local vs Cloud models ?

Here's what you need to keep in mind:

Local models run on your machine. Fast, private, free. But smaller = dumber.

Ollama also offers **cloud models**, massive models (480B parameters) running on their servers. Still free. Much smarter. But your code leaves your machine.

```
ollama launch claude --model qwen3-coder:480b-cloud
```

So for personal projects, I recommend using the cloud model.

For work code with sensitive data, stay local. Don't send company secrets to someone else's server 😉 .